

Chapter 8

‘Be/have’ verbs in historical perspective

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It is cross-linguistically common that verbs whose use in possessive clauses is comparable to that of English *have* are also used impersonally in existential and inverse-locational clauses, but in most of the languages in which a ‘have’ verb also acts as an existential predicator, its possible functions do not include that of copula in plain-locational clauses. The term ‘be/have’ verb refers to verbs involved in a much less common configuration, in which a verb found in possessive clauses like English *have* is also found not only in inverse-locational and existential clauses, but also in the role of copula in plain-locational clauses. After sketching a typology of the verbs projecting possessive clauses and discussing the distribution of ‘be/have’ verbs in the world’s languages, this article analyzes the scenarios that may lead to the emergence of ‘be/have’ verbs in the history of a language.

1 Introduction

The term ‘BE/HAVE’ VERB is the term I propose for verbs that have the ability to act not only as ‘have’ verbs in possessive clauses (and as existential predicators), but also as copulas in plain-locational predication, i.e. in clauses denoting the spatial relationship figure-ground with the perspectivization ‘from figure to ground’, such as English *John is in his office*.

It is cross-linguistically common that, as discussed in Creissels (2023), verbs whose use in possessive clauses is comparable to that of English *have* are also used impersonally in existential clauses (i.e. in clauses in which an entity of any kind is just characterized as constituting an element of some not overtly specified situation, such as English *There are two ways of doing that*) and in inverse-locational clauses (i.e. in clauses that describe the spatial relationship



between a figure and a ground with the perspectivization ‘from ground to figure’, such as English *There is a cat in the tree*, cf. Creissels 2019).¹ However, in most of the languages in which a ‘have’ verb also acts as an existential predicator, its possible functions do not include that of copula in plain-locational clauses (i.e. in clauses that describe the spatial relationship between a figure and a ground with the perspectivization ‘from figure to ground’, such as English *The cat is in the tree*). Example (1) illustrates this cross-linguistically common type of alignment between possessive predication involving a ‘have’ verb, existential predication and locative predication.²

(1) Bulgarian (Indo-European, [bulg1262]; personal documentation)

- a. *Sestra mi ima kotka.*
sister I_{ADP}:1SG have.PRS.I_{S/A}:3SG cat
‘My sister has a cat.’ (possessive clause)
- b. *Ima kotka pod masa-ta.*
have.PRS.I_{S/A}:3SG_{EXPL} cat under table-D
‘There is a cat under the table.’ (inverse-locational clause)
- c. *Kotka-ta e pod masa-ta.*
cat-D be.PRS.I_{S/A}:3SG under table-D
‘The cat is under the table.’ (plain-locational clause)

Example (2) illustrates the same configuration in a West-African language.

(2) Wolof (Atlantic-Congo, [nucl1347]; personal documentation)

- a. *Astu am na muus.*
PRN have PRF.I_{S/A}:3SG cat(clM)
‘Astou has a cat.’ (possessive clause)
- b. *Am na a-m muus ci suufu taabal b-i.*
have PRF.I_{S/A}:3SG_{EXPL} INDF-clM cat(clM) under table(clB) clB-D
‘There is a cat under the table.’ (inverse-locational clause)

¹Däbritz (2025) addresses this question for Siberian Uralic languages.

²The mention ‘personal documentation’ refers to data collected by the author on poorly documented or undocumented languages on which fieldwork was carried out, or to data taken from various sources other than descriptive grammars, or constructed according to the indications given by descriptive grammars. In these cases, the examples have been checked with the help of native speakers. For the examples taken from sources in which they are already provided with glosses, the glosses have been adapted by the author for the sake of consistency.

- c. *Muus m-i mu ngi ci suufu taabal b-i.*
 cat(c1M) c1M-D I_{S/A}:3SG LOC.COP under table(c1B) c1B-D
 'The cat is under the table.' (plain-locational clause)

Example (3) from the Na-Qiangic language Qiang (Sino-Tibetan, [qian1264]) illustrates a much less common configuration, in which a verb whose use in possessive clauses is similar to that of English *have* can also be found not only in inverse-locational and existential clauses, but also in the role of copula in plain-locational clauses. Qiang is a verb-final language with a grammatical relation 'subject' conflating transitive A and intransitive S, manifested in obligatory indexation of subjects on the verb, and no flagging of either subjects or objects. As can be seen in (3), in the plain-locational clauses of Puxi Qiang involving *zə* in the role of copula, the subject represents the figure (hence the presence of the first person form *zə'* in (3a)), whereas in the possessive use of the same verb, the subject represents the possessor (hence the presence of the same first person form *zə'* in (3c)). In other words, in Puxi Qiang, the same verb occurs in possessive clauses in which it behaves like verbs commonly identified as 'have' verbs in language descriptions, and in plain locational clauses in which it behaves like verbs commonly designated as 'be' verbs. In other words, Puxi Qiang *zə* is a 'be/have' verb.

(3) Puxi Qiang (Huang 2004: 93–94)

- a. *ŋa tso zə'.*
 1SG.TOP here **be/have**.I_{S/A}:1
 'I am here.' (plain-locational clause)
- b. *Tci škueškue-ta dzua zə.*
 house around-LOC army **be/have**.I_{S/A}:3
 'There is a team of soldiers around the house.' (inverse-locational clause)
- c. *ŋa tsutsu a-la zə'.*
 1SG.TOP younger.brother one-CLF **be/have**.I_{S/A}:1
 'I have a younger brother.' (possessive clause)

In this article, after sketching a typology of the verbs that have the ability to act as the predicative nucleus of possessive clauses (§2) and summarizing the data I have been able to gather about the distribution of the configuration illustrated by example (3) in the world's languages (§3), I discuss data suggesting possible scenarios that may lead to the emergence of this configuration in the history of a language (§4). §5 summarizes the main conclusions.

2 Verbs of possession, ‘have’ verbs and ‘be/have’ verbs

2.1 Predicative possession between verbal and non-verbal predication

Two types of predicative possession can be recognized, depending on the perspectivization of the possessive relationship: either from possessor to possessee (English *I have a book*) or from possessee to possessor (English *The book is mine*). This article deals exclusively with predicative possession constructions expressing the perspectivization ‘from possessor to possessee’.

Building on Hengeveld (1992) and Stassen (1997), I adopt the definition of non-verbal predication constructions as constructions giving rise to non-elliptical clauses analyzable as consisting of an argument phrase and a predicate phrase in which THE PROPERTY- OR RELATION-DENOTING ELEMENT THAT ACTS AS THE SEMANTIC NUCLEUS OF THE PREDICATE PHRASE IS NOT A VERB. Note that this definition leaves open the possibility that clauses analyzable as instances of non-verbal predication include a verb acting as a copula, i.e. playing a role in the expression of TAM categories (and possibly other distinctions encoded by means of verbal inflection), but not in the identification of the semantic roles expressed by the nominal terms of the clause.

Within this approach to non-verbal predication, even if some functional types of predication are more commonly expressed via constructions meeting the definition of non-verbal predication than others, functional types of predication cannot be a priori classified as being verbal or non-verbal in nature. In particular, predicative possession is typically a functional domain characterized by competition between verbal and non-verbal predication, and the data provided by Stassen (2009) show that there is no obvious unbalance in the cross-linguistic distribution of the verbal and non-verbal types of predicative possession.

2.1.1 Types of possessive clauses analyzable as instances of non-verbal predication

Example (4) illustrates a type of possessive clauses in which a proprietive noun or adjective glossable as ‘provided with possessee’ acts as a predicate assigning the role of possessor to an unflagged noun phrase that constitutes its argument.

- (4) Classical Nahuatl (Uto-Aztecan, [clas1250]; Launey 1981)
Ca tlāca-huā in tēuctli.
ASRT man-PROPR D lord
‘The lord has slaves.’

In the type illustrated by example (5), an adpositional phrase or case-marked noun phrase glossable as 'in possession of N' acts as a predicate assigning the role of possessor to an unflagged noun phrase that constitutes its argument.

- (5) Hausa (Afroasiatic, [haus1257]; Newman 2000: 222)

Yaaròo yanàa dà fensìr̃.
 boy I_{S/A}:3SG.M.LOC.COP with pencil
 'The boy has a pencil.'

In the type illustrated by example (6), an adpositional phrase or case-marked noun phrase glossable as 'in N's personal sphere' acts as a predicate assigning the role of possessee to an unflagged noun phrase that constitutes its argument.

- (6) Estonian (Uralic, [esto1258]; Erelt & Metslang 2006: 258)

Mu-l oled sina.
 1SG-ADESS be.PRS.I_{S/A}:2SG 2SG
 'I have you.'

In the type illustrated by example (7), a possessive-marked noun phrase combines with an existential predicator into a predicate glossable as 'X's possessee exists' that assigns the role of possessor to a noun phrase that constitutes its argument. What is crucial for the possessive interpretation of the construction is not the existential predicator, but the possessive marking of the possessee, and it is interesting to observe that some languages have the same type of construction without any overt existential predicator, as in (8).

- (7) Turkish (Turkic, [nucl1301]; personal documentation)

Murat-in otomobil-i var.
 PRN-GEN car-I_{ADP}:3SG EXIST
 'Murat has a car.'

- (8) Emerillon (Tupian, [emer1243]; Rose 2002: 325)

e-kija
 I_{ADP}:1SG-hammock
 'my hammock' (noun phrase) or 'I have a hammock' (clause)

2.1.2 Types of possessive clauses analyzable as instances of verbal predication

The distinctive property of the possessive clauses analyzable as instances of verbal predication is that the possessive interpretation is not determined by the

coding of the nominal terms but by the lexical meaning of a verb acting as the predicative nucleus of the clause. The verbs having the ability of acting as the predicative nucleus of possessive clauses may be monovalent denominal verbs (propriative verbs), assigning to the sole core nominal term of the clause the role of possessor of an entity belonging to the category denoted by the noun from which they derive, as in (9). Note that the same gloss *PROPR* is used for affixes deriving propriative nouns or adjectives, as in (4) above, and for affixes deriving propriative verbs, as in (9).³

- (9) Kalaallisut (Eskimo-Aleut, [kala1399]; Van Geenhoven 1998: 25)
Angut taana illu-qar-puq.
man that house-*PROPR*-IND.I_s:3SG
'That man has a house.'

However, the verbs acting as the predicative nucleus of possessive clauses are more commonly bivalent verbs that assign the roles of possessor and possessee to two nominal terms of the clauses they project. A distinction can be made between those in which the possessee is expressed as the A term of a transitive construction or the S term of an intransitive construction (i.e., the subject, in the languages that have a grammatical relation 'subject'), and those in which the A term of a transitive construction or the S term of an intransitive construction expresses the role of possessor.

The first possibility is sporadically attested among the indigenous languages of South America with the possessee and the possessor encoded as the A and P terms of a transitive construction. It is also found in Northwest Caucasian and Kartvelian languages with the possessee encoded as the S term of an intransitive construction and the possessor encoded as an indirect object. Most of the verbs projecting possessive clauses whose A or S term expresses the role of possessee derive from an existential or locational verb via applicative derivation. Such possessive clauses can consequently be explained as meaning literally 'Possessee exists for Possessor'. For example, Overall (Forthcoming) shows that Chicham / Jivaroan languages have transitive possessive clauses of this type, as in (10b), to be compared with the intransitive inverse-locational clause (10a).

³Diachronically, a relationship between transitive 'have' verbs and propriative verbs is plausible, since in a language in which a transitive 'have' verb has the ability to incorporate its P, the generalization of the incorporating construction may lead to the obsolescence of the original transitive construction, which automatically converts the former 'have' verb into an affix deriving propriative verbs from nouns.

- (10) Wampis (Chicham, [huam1247]; Peña 2015: 521, 759, quoted by Overall Forthcoming)

- a. *Aánman nápi áwai.*
 aa=numa=ni napi a-ua-i
 outside=LOC=ALL snake exist.IPFV-I_S:3-DECL
 ‘There is a snake (somewhere) outside.’
- b. *Arútam mípa arútiawee.*
 arutam mi=na a-ru-tu-a-ua-i
 power.vision 1SG=ACC exist-APPL-I_P:1SG-IPFV-I_A:3-DECL
 ‘I have an Arutam power.’

Transitive possessive clauses of the same type as (10b) have also been signaled in some varieties of Quechua (Myler 2016) and in Mataguan languages (Vidal & Nercesian Forthcoming).

Example (11) illustrates a possessive verb deriving from a ‘be’ verb via applicativization and projecting clauses in which the possessee is expressed as S, and the possessor as an indirect object.

- (11) West Circassian (Abkhaz-Adyge, [adyg1241]; Arkadiev et al. 2024: 887)
- W-jane-w-jate-xe-r w-jə-ʔe-x-a?*
 I_{ADP}:2SG-mother-I_{ADP}:2SG-father-PL-ABS I_{IO}:2SG-APPL-be-PL-Q
 ‘Do you have parents?’

Example (12) illustrates a similar construction, in which, however, the verb stems glossed ‘be in the sphere of’ cannot be decomposed morphologically. Note that the choice between the two verbs of possession of Georgian illustrated in (12) depends on animacy of the possessee.

- (12) Georgian (Kartvelian, [nucl1302]; personal documentation)
- a. *Vano-s axali megobari hq’avs.*
 Vano-DAT new friend be.in.the.sphere.of.PRS.I_S:3SG.I_{IO}:3SG
 ‘Vano has a new friend.’
- b. *Vano-s axali saxli akvs.*
 Vano-DAT new house be.in.the.sphere.of.PRS.I_S:3SG.I_{IO}:3SG
 ‘Vano has a new house.’

In contrast to the scarcity of the constructions of the type illustrated in examples (10) to (12), clauses projected by verbs of possession in which the A term of a

transitive construction or the S term of an intransitive construction expresses the role of possessor, discussed in more detail in §2.2, are extremely common cross-linguistically. Alongside with the type illustrated in (6) above (characterized by adjunct-like coding of the possessor), they constitute in fact one of the two major types of predicative possession in terms of distribution across geographical areas and language families.

2.2 ‘Have’ verbs

According to the broad definition adopted in this article, a ‘have’ verb is a semantically bivalent verb projecting possessive clauses in which the possessor is coded like the agent of prototypical transitive verbs (A) or like the sole essential participant of a semantically monovalent verb (S).⁴ In the languages that have a grammatical relation ‘subject’ encompassing the agent of prototypical transitive verbs and the sole essential participant of semantically monovalent verbs, ‘have’ verbs can equally be characterized as bivalent possessive verbs whose subject represents the possessor. Cross-linguistically, the vast majority of the verbs that meet this definition of ‘have’ verbs select a coding frame identical to that of prototypical transitive verbs, and consequently meet the narrower definition of ‘have’ verbs found in the literature (including Creissels 2023), according to which transitivity is a definitional feature of ‘have’ verbs. For example, in Mandinka, the verb *sòtó* ‘have’ projects clauses expressing a variety of possessive relationships comparable to that expressed by English *have*, and, as shown in (13), its coding frame is fully aligned with that of a prototypical transitive verb such as *tábi* ‘cook’.

(13) Mandinka (Mande, [mand1436]; personal documentation)

- a. *Fàatú yè kín-òò tábí kèê-lú yè.*
PRN COMPL.TR meal-D cook man.D-PL for
‘Fatou cooked the meal for the men.’ (prototypical transitive clause)
- b. *Fàatú yè báadiŋ-ò-lú sòtó ññ sàatêe tó.*
PRN COMPL.TR relative-D-PL have DEM village.D LOC
‘Fatou has relatives in this village.’ (possessive clause)

Example (14b) illustrates a clause projected by a transitive ‘have’ verb in a language in which, as can be seen from (14a), the transitive construction shows a contrast between ergative-marked A and zero-marked P.

⁴For a discussion of the notion of essential participant and for details about the approach to S, A, and P underlying this paper, readers are referred to Creissels (2024b: chapter 1). Suffice it to mention here that this approach is in line with what Haspelmath (2011) characterizes as the Comrian paradigm.

(14) Central Basque (isolate, [basq1248]; personal documentation)

- a. *Jon-ek bi etxe egin zituen.*
 PRN-ERG two house make.COMPL AUX.I_{ZER}:3PL.I_{ERG}:3SG
 ‘Jon has built two houses.’
- b. *Jon-ek bi seme dauzka.*
 PRN-ERG two son have.I_{ZER}:3PL.I_{ERG}:3SG
 ‘Jon has two sons.’

However, the broad definition of ‘have’ verbs formulated above also encompasses verbs selecting coding frames that variously depart from the transitive construction, but sharing with transitive ‘have’ verbs the essential property of projecting possessive clauses in which the A-like or S-like coding of the possessor characterizes it as the participant having the highest degree of inherent topicality.

Verbs that meet the broad definition of ‘have’ verbs but whose coding frame variously departs from the transitive construction are attested in quite a few languages. However, their status is problematic in a general typology of predicative possession excluding them from the notion of ‘have’ verbs, since the constructions in which they are involved do not meet the definition of any of the other types of predicative possession commonly recognized. The possibility of integrating them into a general typology of predicative possession is therefore an obvious advantage of the broad definition of ‘have’ verbs adopted in this article.

Arabic dialects are a case in point. In Classical Arabic and Modern Standard Arabic, the standard expression of predicative possession is a construction whose literal equivalent in English would be ‘At Possessor is Possessee’, but this situation has not been maintained in Arabic dialects. As discussed in more details in Creissels (2022), most vernacular varieties of Arabic have a predicative possession construction involving a word belonging to a category for which the label ‘pseudo-verb’ is commonly used in descriptions of Arabic dialects, and this possessive (pseudo-)verb meets the broad definition of ‘have’ verbs but not the narrow one.

In vernacular Arabic varieties, pseudo-verbs are words of non-verbal origin that have acquired uses in which they can be analyzed synchronically as projecting clauses, and in which they have acquired some properties typical of verbs in Arabic morphosyntax, in particular in the expression of negation. For example, Moroccan Arabic has a pseudo-verb *?and* ‘have’ cognate with the preposition *?and* ‘at’, but synchronically distinct from it in its syntactic and semantic properties. As illustrated in (15), *?and* ‘have’, contrary to *?and* ‘at’, obligatorily combines with a person-number-gender suffix indexing the possessor, but cannot be

followed by a noun phrase expressing the semantic role of possessor. A possessor noun phrase can only precede *ʔand*, whereas the possessee is expressed as an unflagged noun phrase that follows *ʔand*.

- (15) Moroccan Arabic (Afroasiatic, [moro1292]; Caubet 1993: 51–52)
Ḥmad ʔand-u ʔl-ktāb.
PRN have-1:3SG.M book
‘Ahmed has the book.’

The coding frame of Moroccan *ʔand* ‘have’ is similar to the basic transitive construction as regards constituent order and the obligatory indexation of the participant that can be expressed as a pre-verbal noun phrase. However, it cannot be analyzed as an instance of the transitive construction for the following two reasons: the paradigm of obligatory indexes suffixed to *ʔand* is distinct from the standard paradigm of subject indexes and more similar (although not identical) to the paradigm of object indexes (the explanation being that it originates historically from the paradigm of indexes representing the complement of prepositions), and, contrary to the object of transitive verbs, the participant encoded as a postverbal noun phrase in possessive clauses cannot be alternatively represented by an index suffixed to the verb.

2.3 The historical origin of ‘have’ verbs

A major source of ‘have’ verbs is the emergence of ‘have’ verbs as the result of a process of semantic bleaching affecting transitive verbs expressing meanings such as ‘take’, ‘grasp’, ‘hold’, ‘get’, ‘bear’ (Creissels 1979: 637–659, Givón 1984: 103, Heine 1997: 48, Stassen 2009: 63). This evolution is widely attested not only in various branches of the Indo-European family, but also in many other language families all around the world.⁵

A second source of ‘have’ verbs is the widespread tendency of predicative possession constructions originally belonging to other types to acquire coding properties making them similar to a ‘have’ construction. As rightly observed by Stassen (2009: 208–243), this kind of evolution, commonly designated as HAVE-DRIFT, may affect constructions that originally belong to any other type of predicative possession, and is in fact a major source of typological change in the way languages express predicative possession, cf. also Creissels (2023). The evolution of predicative possession in Arabic, evoked in §2.2, illustrates this possibility.

⁵Interestingly, ‘have’ verbs resulting from this kind of semantic shift are particularly common in pidgins and creoles, cf. Michaelis et al. (2013).

A third possible source of 'have' verbs is the lexicalization of the applicative form of locational or existential verbs. As already mentioned in §2.2, the applicativization of locational or existential verbs may yield verbs of possession with which the possessor is coded as the P term of a transitive construction. However, due to the remarkable semantic plasticity of applicativization, the applicativization of verbs expressing location, posture or existence may also yield 'have' verbs with which the possessor is coded as the A term of a transitive construction or the S term of an intransitive construction. This possibility can be illustrated by the Australian language Diyari, where a verb still identifiable formally as the applicative form of 'sit' has become a 'have' verb, cf. example (16). This is an instance of lexicalization in the sense that, synchronically, the construction illustrated in (16) can no longer be analyzed as an applicative construction, since the S of the base verb expresses the role of person who sits, whereas the A of the derived verb expresses the role of possessor.

- (16) Diyari (Pama-Nyungan, [dier1241]; Austin 2024: 402)
Yundru karna tharla ngama-lka-yi?
 2SG.ERG person name.ACC sit-APPL-PRS
 'Do you have an Aboriginal name?'

2.4 'Be/have' verbs

'BE/HAVE' VERBS have been defined in §1 as verbs that have the ability to act not only as 'have' verbs in possessive clauses and as existential predicators, but also as copulas in plain-locational predication, i.e. in clauses denoting the spatial relationship figure-ground with the perspectivization 'from figure to ground', such as English *John is in his office*. This configuration, already illustrated in the introduction by an example from the Na-Qiangic language Qiang, is also found in Indonesian (17).

- (17) Indonesian (Austronesian, [indo1316]; Sneddon 1996: 264)
- a. *Saya tidak **ada** uang.*
 1SG NEG be/have money
 'I don't have any money.' (possessive predication)
 - b. *Di Indonesia tidak **ada** kanguru.*
 in PRN NEG be/have kangaroo
 'In Indonesia there are no kangaroos.' (inverse-locational predication)

- c. *Ayah tidak ada di kantor.*
 father NEG be/have in office
 ‘Father isn’t in the office.’ (plain-locational predication)

Some of the verbs that meet this definition of ‘be/have’ verbs also have a copular use in nominal and/or adjectival predication (i.e. in clauses such as *John is a teacher*, *John is tall*). This is not the case in Qiang or in Indonesian, but example (18) illustrates such a configuration in the Bantu language Kikuyu, an AVP/SV language in which A in transitive predication and S in intransitive predication are obligatorily indexed by means of the same set of verbal prefixes.⁶

(18) Kikuyu (Atlantic-Congo, [kiku1240]; Li & Navarro 2015: 86, 89, 93)

- a. *Tũ-rĩ n-gari.*
I_{S/A}:1PL-be/have SG-car(cl9)
 ‘We have a car.’ (possessive predication)
- b. *Ha-rĩ benjũ metha-inĩ.*
I_{S/A}:cl16_{EXPL}-be/have SG.pencil(cl9) SG.table(cl9)-LOC
 ‘There is a pencil on the table.’ (inverse-locational predication)
- c. *I-bera rĩ-rĩ gĩ-kombe-inĩ.*
SG-pear(cl5) I_{S/A}:cl5-be/have SG-cup(cl7)-LOC
 ‘The pear is in the cup.’ (plain-locational predication)
- d. *Mũ-ti-rĩ arimũ.*
I_{S/A}:2PL-NEG-be/have PL.teachers(cl2)
 ‘You are not teachers.’ (nominal predication)
- e. *Tũ-rĩ a-rũaru.*
I_{S/A}:1PL-be/have cl2-sick
 ‘We are sick.’ (adjectival predication)

3 ‘Be/have’ verbs in the world’s languages

Two hotspots of ‘be/have’ verbs can be identified: Mainland South East Asia in the first place, and to a lesser extent the Ghana-Togo region in West Africa. The other languages for which I have been able to find mentions of the existence of a ‘be/have’ verb show no genetic or areal clustering. However, in the absence

⁶The role played by the expletive S/A index of class 16 (etymologically a locative index) in the inverse-locational clause (18b) is comparable to that of *there* in the English equivalent of this clause.

of a more systematic investigation, I cannot exclude that this might be due to accidental gaps in the data.

3.1 'Be/have' verbs in Mainland South East Asia

'Be/have' verbs are particularly prominent in Mainland South East Asia. In this area, the data analyzed by Chappell & Creissels (2019) and Chappell & Lü (2022) show the existence of 'be/have' verbs in the following languages:

- one Hmongic language (Yanghao, [nort2747]),
- two Austroasiatic languages (Bugan, [buga1247] and Mang [mang1378]),
- among Sino-Tibetan languages, Jingpho (Brahmaputran [jing1260]), Tujia (unclassified Sino-Tibetan [tuji1244]), several languages belonging to the Burmese-Lolo, Na-Qiangic and Karenic branches of Sino-Tibetan, three Sinitic languages (Haikou Southern Min [hain1238], Linxia [hez1244] and Dabu Hakka [hakk1236]), and four varieties of Bai (unclassified Sino-Tibetan, [baic1239]).

In Bai languages (and only in Bai languages) the 'be/have' verb is also used as a copula in equative clauses (nominal predication).

3.2 'Be/have' verbs in the Ghana-Togo region

In West Africa, 'be/have' verbs are attested in several languages of the Ghana-Togo region belonging to the Kwa and Gur subfamilies of the Atlantic-Congo family:

- Akan (Tano, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [akan1250]; Boadi 1971, Redden & Owusu 1995)
- Efutu (Tano, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [efut1241]; Agyeman 2016),
- Gikyode (Tano, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [giky1238]; Gikyode dictionary online),⁷
- Gonja (Tano, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [gonj1241]; Gonja dictionary online),⁸
- Nkami (Tano, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [nkam1239]; Asante 2017),

⁷<https://www.webonary.org/gikyode/browse>, accessed 10 April 2024.

⁸<https://www.webonary.org/gonja/browse>, accessed 10 April 2024.

- Nkonya (Tano, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [nkon1248]; Reineke 1972 and Nkonya dictionary online),⁹
- Likpe (Na-Togo, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [sekp1241]; Ameka 2007, Ameka 2009 and personal communication),
- Tuwuli (Ka-Togo, Kwa, Atlantic-Congo, [tuwu1238]; Harley 2005),
- Lama (Gurunsi, Gur, Atlantic-Congo, [lama1275]; Simnara 2019).

Tano languages are particularly well represented among the languages of the Ghana-Togo region that have ‘be/have’ verbs. Moreover, with the exception of Akan, all the Tano languages in this list belong to the Guang subgroup, which apparently shows the highest concentration of languages with ‘be/have’ verbs in this area.

3.3 ‘Be/have’ verbs in other parts of the world

The other languages for which I have been able to find mentions of the existence of a ‘be/have’ verb show no areal or genetic clustering:

- Indonesian (Malayo-Sumbawan; Sneddon 1996),
- Cheke Holo (Oceanic, Austronesian, [chek1238]; Boswell 2018),
- Diu Indo-Portuguese (Portuguese-based creole, [dama1278]; Cardoso 2009),
- Gulf Pidgin Arabic (Arabic-based pidgin, [pidg1248]; Bakir 2014),
- Français Tirailleur (a French-based pidgin that was used as a lingua franca by West African soldiers and their white officers in the French colonial army, [fran1267]; Skirkgård 2013),
- Iatmul (Ndu, Sepik, [iatm1242]; Jendraschek 2012),
- Kikuyu (Bantu, Benue-Congo; Li & Navarro 2015),
- some varieties of !Xun (Kx’a, [juho1239]; Heine & König 2015).

⁹<https://www.webonary.org/nkonya/browse>, accessed 10 April 2024.

4 Possible origins of 'be/have' verbs

For some of the languages mentioned in §3, the data at my disposal are not suggestive of any particular historical scenario for the emergence of 'be/have' verbs. In particular, all that can be said about the Tano languages listed in §3.2 is that their 'be/have' verbs are certainly reflexes of the same root (they all consist of a labial consonant *b* or *w* and a back vowel *ɔ*, *o* or *ɔ*). In the Tano languages that do not have a 'be/have' verb, a reflex of the same root is found as a locational copula, e.g. Baule (Central Tano, Atlantic-Congo, [baou1238]) *wo* 'be at', Nawuri (Guang, Atlantic-Congo, [nawu1242]) *bɔ* 'be at', and at least some of them have a 'have' verb with a transparent etymology. For example Chumburung (Guang, Atlantic-Congo, [chum1261]) *de* 'have' is also used with the meaning 'take'. Although such observations are not fully conclusive, they at least leave open the possibility that a 'be/have' verb was already present in the ancestor of Tano languages, and lost its possessive use in some of them due to the development of alternative ways of expressing predicative possession.

For some others of the languages mentioned in §3, however, there is more or less solid evidence that the 'be/have' verb results from the evolution of a word that was originally either a 'have' verb (§4.1), a locational copula (§4.2 and §4.3), an existential predicator (§4.4), or the applicative form of an existential verb (§4.5).

4.1 'Have' verb > 'be/have' verb

In some of the South East Asian languages in which the data analyzed by Chappell & Creissels (2019) and Chappell & Lü (2022) show the existence of a 'be/have' verb, the verb in question also has transitive uses with meanings such as 'take'. This is in particular the case for the Puxi Qiang 'be/have' verb *zə* illustrated in example (3) above.

Since it is difficult to imagine the direct conversion of a 'take' verb into a locational copula, whereas 'have' verbs resulting from the semantic bleaching of 'take' verbs are cross-linguistically common, the reasonable hypothesis in such a configuration is the following three-stage evolution:

- a 'take' verb was first converted into a 'have' verb;
- subsequently, the 'have' verb acquired the possibility of being used as an existential predicator and as a copula in inverse-locational predication;
- finally its copular use extended to all locational clauses, irrespective of the distinction between plain- and inverse-locational predication.

The first stage of this evolution is a scenario particularly well-attested cross-linguistically, in particular (but not only) in various branches of Indo-European, cf. for example Indo-European **g^{hab}* ‘seize, take’ > Latin *habēre* ‘have’.

The second stage is also a well-attested type of historical change, analyzed in detail in Creissels (2023), cf. for example Old Spanish (Indo-European, [olds1249]) *haber* ‘have’ > Modern Spanish (Indo-European, [stan1288]) *haber* ‘there be’.

The third stage, by which an existential predicator extends its use from inverse-locational clauses to plain-locational clauses, seems to be less common in the history of languages. However, some clear cases of such an evolution can be found in the world’s languages, as in Arabic-based Pidgins or Creoles, and in some Turkic languages.

Many vernacular Arabic varieties have an existential predicator *fī(h)*, etymologically ‘in it’. As a rule, *fī(h)* occurs only in existential and inverse-locational clauses, but the extension of its use to plain-locational clauses, illustrated in (19), is one of the features that characterize the pidginized/creolized varieties of Arabic spoken in Sudan.¹⁰

- (19) Sudanese Arabic-based pidgins/creoles (Miller 2002: 32)

Úwo *fī* *fī* *bét*.

3SG LOC.COP in house

‘(S)he is at home.’

This evolution also occurred in the Turkic languages of Northeast Siberia (Sakha and Dolgan). Most Turkic languages have an existential predicator (Turkish *var*), reconstructed as **bār* (with the same meaning) in Proto-Turkic. In most Turkic languages (including Turkish), the reflexes of **bār* are used in inverse-locational predication, but not in plain-locational predication, cf. (20). However, as illustrated in (21) for Sakha, in Sakha and Dolgan, this existential predicator has extended its use to plain-locational predication, resulting in locational clauses in which the contrast between the two possible perspectivizations of the ground-figure relationship is manifested in constituent order only.

- (20) Turkish (personal knowledge)

a. *Kedi bahçe-de*.

cat garden-LOC

‘The cat is in the garden.’ (plain-locational predication)

¹⁰Note that example (19) includes both the preposition *fī* ‘in’ and the predicator *fī* whose historical origin is an inflected form of the same preposition meaning ‘in it’.

- b. *Bahçe-de bir kedi var.*
 garden-LOC one cat EXIST
 'There is a cat in the garden.' (inverse-locational predication)

(21) Sakha (Turkic, [yaku1245]; Xaritonov 1987: 16)

- a. *Xarandaas ostuol-ga baar.*
 pencil table-LOC LOC.COP
 'The pencil is on the table.' (plain-locational predication)
- b. *Ostuol-ga xarandaas baar.*
 table-LOC pencil LOC.COP
 'There is a pencil on the table.' (inverse-locational predication)

4.2 Locational copula > 'be/have' verb as the result of changes affecting a possessive construction of the type 'At Possessor is Possessee'

In some of the South East Asian languages for which the data analyzed by Chappell & Creissels (2019) and Chappell & Lü (2022) show the existence of a 'be/have' verb, the verb in question is also attested as an intransitive posture verb, or as an intransitive verb whose meaning implies location, such as 'dwell' or 'stick'. For example, Puxi Qiang has been mentioned above as having a 'be/have' verb illustrating the evolutionary path 'take' > 'have' > 'there be' > 'be at', but in the same Na-Qiangic group of Sino-Tibetan languages, Naxi has a 'be/have' verb *zi*³³ possibly cognate with *zi*⁵⁵ 'lie'.

(22) Naxi (Sino-Tibetan, [naxi1245]; Chappell & Lü 2022: 39–40)

- a. *Zue²¹ tsua³³=kɣ³³ t^he²¹ ʒi⁵⁵ jɿ³³.*
 child bed=on DUR lie SENS
 'The child is lying/sleeping in the bed.'
- b. *ŋu²¹ ŋɿ³³ ŋgɿ³³ nɣ⁵⁵ me³³=lɔ²¹ t^he²¹ ta⁵⁵ ʒi³³.*
 2SG 1SG GEN heart=in DUR always be/have
 'You've always been in my heart.' (plain-locational clause)
- c. *Ze²¹ k^hɔ³³ tɕ^hɿ³³ k^hɔ³³ bɣ²¹ se²¹, ɲɿ²¹ mɿ³³ ʒi³³.*
 well this CLF be.dry PFV water NEG be/have
 'The well is dry and there's no water (inside).' (existential clause)

- d. ζi^{33} $tʂ^{h33}$ ky^{55} cix^{55} ηgy^{33} , ti^{55} we^{55} ηgy^{33} se^{21} me^{33} , pe^{33} sr^{55}
 person this CLF money have social.status have besides capacity
 ʒi^{33} $mɿ^{55}$ sr^{33} .
 be/have PRT
 ‘He’s not only rich and of high social status, but he has the capacity
 as well.’ (possessive clause)

Since the grammaticalization of posture verbs and of verbs expressing meanings such as ‘remain’ as locational copulas is a widely-attested phenomenon in the history of languages, it seems plausible that the first stage in the evolution leading to the emergence of a ‘be/have’ verb in the languages that have a configuration of the type illustrated in (22) was the grammaticalization of intransitive posture verbs (or of other intransitive verbs whose meaning implies location) as locational copulas via semantic bleaching.

Given that possessive clauses of the type ‘At Possessor is Possessee’ constitute a widespread type of predicative possession, in particular among Tibeto-Burman languages, the second stage of the evolution was probably the development of the use of the locational copula in possessive clauses of the type ‘At Possessor is Possessee’.

Finally, as discussed in detail by Creissels (2023: §5.3), it is not uncommon that possessive predication constructions of the type ‘At Possessor is Possessee’ have a variant expressing topicalization of the possessor, in which the left-dislocated possessor phrase loses the adjunct-like flagging that characterizes it in the absence of topicalization, yielding constructions glossable as ‘(As for) Possessor, there is Possessee’ whose generalization may lead to the reanalysis of the construction with an unflagged possessor phrase as a construction in which the existential predicator acts as a ‘have’ verb. Chappell & Creissels (2019) show that Burmese (Sino-Tibetan [nucl1310]) can be analyzed as attesting a transitional stage in this evolution.

4.3 Locational copula > ‘be/have’ verb as the result of changes affecting a possessive construction of the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’

4.3.1 The case of Kikuyu

Kikuyu has a comitative preposition *na* ‘with’, a regular reflex of the Bantu comitative preposition *na*, illustrated in example (23).

- (23) Kikuyu (Li & Navarro 2015: 110)

Mũ-timia nĩ-a-ra-cok-ire mũ-ciĩ na
 SG-woman(cl1) I_{S/A}:cl1-NRPST-return-COMPL SG-home(cl3) with
ci-ana.
 PL-child(cl8)

‘The woman returned home with the children.’

There can be little doubt that the historical change responsible for the emergence of the Kikuyu ‘be/have’ verb *rĩ* illustrated in example (18), reproduced here as (24), is the mere deletion of this comitative preposition in a predicative possession construction ‘NP_{POSSESSOR} *rĩ* na NP_{POSSESSEE}’ lit. ‘Possessor is with Possessee’, where *rĩ* [rɪ] is the regular reflex of the Bantu copula **dɪ*.

- (24) Kikuyu (Li & Navarro 2015: 86, 89, 93)

- a. *Tũ-rĩ n-gari.*
 I_{S/A}:1PL-be/have SG-car(cl9)
 ‘We have a car.’ (possessive predication)
- b. *Ha-rĩ benjũ metha-inĩ.*
 I_{S/A}:cl16_{EXPL}-be/have SG.pencil(cl9) SG.table(cl9)-LOC
 ‘There is a pencil on the table.’ (inverse-locational predication)
- c. *I-bera rĩ-rĩ gĩ-kombe-inĩ.*
 SG-pear(cl5) I_{S/A}:cl5-be/have SG-cup(cl7)-LOC
 ‘The pear is in the cup.’ (plain-locational predication)
- d. *Mũ-ti-rĩ arimũ.*
 I_{S/A}:2PL-NEG-be/have PL.teachers(cl2)
 ‘You are not teachers.’ (nominal predication)
- e. *Tũ-rĩ a-rũaru.*
 I_{S/A}:1PL-be/have cl2-sick
 ‘We are sick.’ (adjectival predication)

The comparative data that support this analysis are that, on the one hand, constructions glossable as ‘Possessor is with Possessee’ are by far the most widespread type of predicative possession across the Bantu language family (Creissels 2024a), and on the other hand, reflexes of **dɪ* acting as copulas (and only as copulas) are pervasive across the Bantu language family. Moreover, the creation of ‘have’ verbs resulting from the fusion and reanalysis of the sequence ‘copula + comitative preposition’ in possessive constructions of the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’ is a very common process in Bantu (Creissels 2024a). In

this context, the deletion of the comitative preposition that occurred in Kikuyu (resulting in the creation of a ‘be/have’ verb) can be viewed as a borderline case of this general trend toward converting comitative-possessive constructions into have-possessive constructions.

Moreover, in Kikuyu, the original construction ‘NP_{POSSESSOR} *rĩ* *na* NP_{POSSESSEE}’, where *rĩ* acts as a copula, still exists in competition with the construction ‘NP_{POSSESSOR} *rĩ* NP_{POSSESSEE}’, where *rĩ* acts as a ‘have’ verb in a construction at least superficially similar to the transitive construction. I checked this with a corpus of Kikuyu proverbs available on the Internet in which possessive clauses abound,¹¹ and it turned out that in this corpus, both possibilities are widely attested. According to Li & Navarro (2015: 92), in the possessive clauses of Kikuyu, “the presence of *na* highlights the immediateness of the possession, so that a possessive clause lacking *na* indicates more permanent possession”, cf. example (25).

(25) Kikuyu (Li & Navarro 2015: 92)

- a. *N-dĩ* *na* *m-buku*.
I_{S/A}:1PL-be/have with SG-book(cl9)
‘I have a book (in my possession at the moment).’
(*rĩ* as a ‘be’ verb) in a possessive clause of the be-with type)
- b. *N-dĩ* *m-buku*.
I_{S/A}:1PL-be/have SG-book(cl9)
‘I own a book.’ (*rĩ* as a ‘have’ verb)

I am aware of no other Bantu language in which a ‘be/have’ verb would have emerged as the result of the deletion of the comitative preposition in a construction of the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’.

4.3.2 The case of Lama

Although the available evidence is less conclusive than in the case of Kikuyu, the same historical scenario is probably responsible for the existence of a ‘be/have’ verb *wɛ* in Lama. The use of this verb as a copula in plain-locational predication and as a ‘have’ verb is illustrated in (26).

¹¹<https://africanmanners.wordpress.com/2012/07/07/gikuyu-proverbs-1000-in-total>, accessed 10 April 2024.

(26) Lama (Simnara 2019: 198, 202)

- a. *Lóór nqá cì wé ló?*
 car DEM owner be/have where
 ‘Where is the owner of this car? (plain-locational clause)’
- b. *Má wé lóór.*
 1SG be/have car
 ‘I have a car.’ (possessive clause)

The hypothesis that the possessive use of the ‘be/have’ verb of Lama results from the deletion of a comitative preposition in a construction that originally belonged to the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’ is supported by data from Tem and Kabiye, two languages very closely related to Lama.¹² In both Tem (Atlantic Congo, [temm1241]) and Kabiye (Atlantic Congo, [kabi1261]), a verb *wé* formally identical to the ‘be/have’ verb of Lama is attested as a copula but cannot be used as a ‘have’ verb, whereas predicative possession involves a verb *wéna* ‘have’ whose obvious etymology is the freezing of the sequence ‘be + with’ in a predicative possession construction of the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’.

4.3.3 The case of Iatmul

The creation of a ‘be/have’ verb as the consequence of the deletion of the comitative preposition in a predicative possession construction that originally belonged to the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’ is also the scenario suggested by the data of the closely related Papuan languages Iatmul (Jendraschek 2012) and Manambu (Ndu, [mana1298]; Aikhenvald 2008).

Iatmul and Manambu possessive clauses involve a verb (Iatmul *ti’ ~ li’*, Manambu *tə*) which is basically a verb ‘stay’ used as a locational copula. Judging from the data provided by Aikhenvald, the possessive construction of Manambu can be straightforwardly analyzed as involving a ‘have’ verb, but the situation of Iatmul is more complex, and suggests the same development path as that already proposed for Kikuyu and Lama.

In Iatmul, according to Jendraschek, three distinct constructions are possible for possessive clauses. They all involve the verb *ti’ ~ li’* ‘stay’, and no difference in meaning is mentioned between them. The most frequent one, illustrated in (27a), belongs to the type ‘Possessor is with Possessee’. The alternative constructions are a construction that can be glossed as ‘Of Possessor is Possessee’ (27b), and a

¹²Lama, Tem and Kabiye are classified in the same subgroup of Gurunsi languages, known as Eastern Gurunsi.

construction with no flagging of either the possessor or the possessee, in which consequently *li'* can be analyzed as acting as a 'have' verb (27c).

(27) Iatmul (Jendraschek 2012: 215, 216)

- a. *Nyaan gusa okwi li'-di'.*
child paddle with **be/have-3SG.M**
'The child had a paddle.' lit. 'The child stayed with a paddle.'
- b. *Wun-a saanya wugi li'-ka.*
1SG-GEN money that.which **be/have-PRS(SR)**
'I have money.' lit. 'Of me money is that which stays.'
- c. *Nyaan gusa li'-di'.*
child paddle **be/have-3SG.M**
'The child had a paddle.' lit. 'The child stayed a paddle.'

I am not aware of comparative data that might support a particular scenario, but it seems difficult to imagine a motivation for the addition of a comitative preposition flagging the possessee phrase in the construction of a verb that would have been originally a 'have' verb. Moreover, as discussed in detail by Stassen (2009), the general trend in the structural changes that may affect predicative possession construction is that constructions that do not involve 'have' verbs tend to change in a way that makes them more similar to the 'have' type of predicative possession, but not the other way round. Consequently, a reasonable hypothesis is that, in the same way as in Kikuyu and in Lama, the construction in which *li'* can be analyzed as acting as a 'have' verb resulted from the deletion of the comitative postposition in a possessive construction that was originally 'Possessor is with Possessee'.

4.4 Existential predicator > 'be/have' verb

In §4.1 it has been mentioned that, in the Arabic-based pidgins or creoles of Sudan, an existential predicator found as *fī(h)* in many vernacular varieties of Arabic (whose ultimate origin is *fī-hi* 'in it') has become a general locational copula marking locational clauses irrespective of the perspectivization of the figure-ground relationship. The same evolution occurred in Gulf Pidgin Arabic, as illustrated in (28b), but in addition to that, *fī* in Gulf Pidgin Arabic has acquired the function of a 'have' verb (28c), and also that of an equative copula (28d), resulting in the configuration already mentioned for Kikuyu (cf. §2.4) and Bai languages (cf. §3.1).

(28) Gulf Pidgin Arabic (Bakir 2014: 418)

- a. *Fī moni mā-fī muškila.*
be/have money NEG-be/have problem
 'If there is money, there is no problem.'
- b. *Ana bēt fī wara dukkān.*
 1SG home **be/have** behind shop
 'My home is behind the shop.'
- c. *Alhīn walla ana fī talāta arba baččā.*
 now by.God 1SG **be/have** three four child
 'I swear I have three, four children.'
- d. *Ana fī maskīn sah walla lā?*
 1SG **be/have** poor right or no
 'I am a poor fellow, right?'

Given that it can be taken for granted that this situation developed from the use of *fī* as an existential predicator, the emergence of a 'be/have' verb in Gulf Pidgin Arabic can be analyzed as resulting from the conjunction of two distinct evolutions already discussed in the previous sections. The starting point of both evolutions was the use of *fī* in existential and inverse-locational clauses. On the one hand, in a construction combining existential predication with a topic pragmatically interpreted as denoting a possessor (something like (*As for*) *X*, *there is Y* interpreted as 'X has Y'), the existential predicator has been reanalyzed as a 'have' verb. On the other hand, the existential has extended its use from inverse-locational clauses to plain-locational clauses, thus acquiring the status of general locational copula.

The same explanation applies to the distribution of *y(en)a* across equative, locational, existential and possessive clauses in Français Tirailleur (a French-based pidgin that was used as a lingua franca by West African soldiers and their white officers in the French colonial army), whose origin is French *il y (en) a* 'there is (some)'.

Although the available evidence is less conclusive, comparative data suggest that the emergence of the Indonesian 'be/have' verb *ada* might have resulted from the same conjunction of two evolutions extending the use of an existential predicator: on the one hand, emergence of a 'have' possessive construction via reanalysis of a construction combining existential predication with a topic interpreted pragmatically as denoting a possessor, and on the other hand, extension of the use of the same existential predicator to plain-locational clauses. The

main piece of evidence is that cognates of *ada* are widespread across Western Malayo-Polynesian languages, and by far their most widespread use is that of existential predicator. Additional pieces of evidence are that, on the one hand, the use of *ada* is optional in plain-locational clauses, and on the other hand, in possessive clauses, the *ada* construction is in competition with a construction involving propriative verbs derived by means of the prefix *ber*, e.g. *anak* ‘child’ > *ber-anak* ‘have children’.

4.5 Applicative form of an existential predicator > ‘be/have’ verb

In general, existential predicators have the ability to occur in the same form in two types of clauses. By definition, existential predicators can be found in existential clauses in the strictest sense of this term, i.e., in clauses giving no overt indication about the situation in which the referent of the argument of the existential predicator can be found. However, existential predicators commonly also occur in clauses in which they combine with a locative expression, the S term in the construction of the existential predicator then fulfilling the semantic role of figure in a ground-figure relationship.

A remarkable property of the Kx’a language !Xun is that it has an existential verb *gè* which in its underived form cannot combine with a phrase expressing location. In !Xun, the use of the existential verb *gè* in locational clauses requires applicative marking. Moreover, as illustrated in (29), in some varieties of !Xun, the applicative form *gèā* ~ *gèà* has the ability of projecting clauses that constitute the usual way of expressing not only locational predication, but also predicative possession (Heine & König 2015: 80–84, 233–235). (29b) is a plain-locational clause in which the applied phrase expresses the ground in a figure-ground relationship, whereas in (29c), the applied phrase is interpreted as the possessee in a possessor-possessee relationship.

(29) !Xun (Heine & König 2015: 82, 83, 233)

- a. *Tsìrì(-sǐ) rē gè?*
chair-PL Q there.be
‘Are there chairs?’
- b. *Tsìrì m̄ gè-à tc’ū n’ŋ.*
chair TOP there.be-APPL house inside
‘The stool is in the house.’
- c. *Nā gè-ā gùmì.*
1SG there.be-APPL cattle
‘I have a cow.’

A possible explanation for this situation is that the construction in which *gèā ~ gèà* acts as a copula in locational clauses (including plain-locational ones) is a locative applicative (i.e., a construction in which applicative derivation licenses an applied phrase expressing the semantic role of location), whereas the use of *gèā ~ gèà* as a 'have' verb results from the lexicalization of a comitative applicative (i.e., a construction in which applicative derivation originally licensed an applied phrase expressing the semantic role of companion, subsequently reinterpreted as expressing the role of possessee).

A possible objection is that, synchronically, *gèā ~ gèà* does not seem to be productively used with the meaning 'be with'. However, Heine & König (2015: 83) quote an example from an old description of a !Xun variety in which *gèā* unquestionably expresses a comitative meaning, which lends some support to this analysis.

5 Conclusion

In this article, after sketching a typology of the verbs that have the ability to project possessive clauses and defining the notion of 'be/have' verb, I have tried to show that for at least some of the languages with 'be/have' verbs, there are comparative data supporting the reconstruction of four possible historical scenarios in which a word that was originally a 'have' verb, a locational copula, an existential predicator or the applicative form of an existential verb is converted into a 'be/have' verb.

In the scenario discussed in §4.3, a SINGLE-STEP CHANGE (the deletion of the comitative preposition in a predicative possession construction of the type 'Possessor is with Possessee') directly results in the emergence of a 'be/have' verb.

The other scenarios discussed in §4 are COMPLEX SCENARIOS combining two changes which, with the exception of the creation of a locational copula and of a 'have' verb via applicativization of an existential verb, are well-attested separately in the history of locational, existential and possessive constructions:

- the scenario analyzed in §4.1 combines the acquisition of the function of existential predicator by a have verb and the conversion of an existential predicator into a general locational copula;
- the scenario analyzed in §4.2 combines the development of a possessive predication construction of the type 'At Possessor is Possessee' and the acquisition of transitive features by a possessive predication construction that originally belongs to the type 'At Possessor is Possessee' (*have*-drift);

- the scenario analyzed in §4.4 combines the conversion of an existential predicator into a general locational copula and the acquisition of transitive features by a possessive predication construction that originally belongs to the type ‘At Possessor is Possessee’ (*have*-drift);
- the scenario analyzed in §4.5 combines the creation of a locational copula and of a ‘have’ verb via applicativization of an existential verb in a language where the same applicative marker can be found in locative-applicative and comitative-applicative functions.

Abbreviations

A	the nominal term of transitive clauses that represents the agent if the verb projecting the clause is a prototypical transitive verb	I _{S/A}	index cross-referencing the S term of a transitive clause or the A term of a transitive clause (subject index)
ADESS	adessive	I _{ZER}	index cross-referencing a zero-marked term of the clause
CL	gender-number agreement pattern (class)	LOC.COP	locational copula
CLF	classifier	NRPST	near past
COMPL	completive	P	the nominal term of transitive clauses that represents the patient if the verb projecting the clause is a prototypical transitive verb
D	definite determiner or default determiner	PRN	proper name
DECL	declarative	PROPR	propriative
EXIST	existential predicator	PRT	discourse particle
EXPL	expletive	S	the nominal term of intransitive clauses that represents the sole essential participant if the verb projecting the clause is a semantically monovalent verb
I	index		
I _{ADP}	index cross-referencing an adnominal possessor (possessive index)	SENS	sensory
I _{ERG}	index cross-referencing an ergative-marked term of the clause	SR	subordinator
I _{IO}	index cross-referencing an indirect object		
I _P	index cross-referencing the P term of a transitive clause (object index)		

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